

(Last) Education Session #10



Firm-Specific Interview Details, Managing Nerves &
Planning Ahead

A reminder!

- Run your own race
- Control the controllables
- Talk to yourself how you'd talk to a close friend
- Stay healthy – go outside, eat well, be social



Firm-Specific Interview Experiences

A couple of things for you to keep in mind:

- The information in the subsequent slides comes from the experiences of MBA2s
- We have tried to collate a variety of interview experiences. However, **the formats and questions are not set in stone** – firms might change them every year (for example – Bain had 2 power rounds in 2022, and only 1 in 2023 and 2021)
- To know the specifics of interview processes, reach out to MBA2s - internship data linked [here](#)

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences – McKinsey

Format

1 Power day – consisted of 3 interviews each with a PEI question prior to the case. One with an Associate Partner, one with a Partner, and one with a Senior Partner (in that order)

Type of cases

Retail and Banking – focused on growth strategies, acquisitions, and non-profits

Behavioral questions

PEIs were given word-for-word in advance of my interviews

Any curveballs?

"What else?" Asked twice during a case about the same prompt. Interviewer didn't allow me to round.

Office-specific nuances?

Each office is different – check on your interview invite to see what your interview will look like



PRO TIP

- Long process – have a game plan to manage nerves and stay energetic throughout the process!
- Be yourself – even when the interviewer is trying to throw you off-track, they want to see that you have a personality that can shine through even in stressful situations

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences - BCG

Format

1 power round with 2 back-to-back cases. Behavioral questions asked before case interview

Type of cases

Interviewee led - EV lawn mower, contact lenses, F1 tickets, tissue profitability. No fixed industry pattern here

Behavioral questions

Why BCG, why this office? For digital – why digital consulting?

Any curveballs?

Some of the interviewers changed at the last second for a lot of people, don't get stressed if you have a different interviewer than the one initially allotted

Office-specific nuances?

None – format and cases almost uniform across offices



PRO TIP

- The interview itself is not super difficult or confusing. Stay calm, and don't lose sight of the initial goal!
- Be very conversational and try to make a connection with the interviewer.

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences - Bain

Format

1 power round with 3 back-to-back interviews; 2 case interviews and 1 behavioral interview

Type of cases

M&A synergies, growth strategy

Behavioral questions

Why Bain, why consulting, why this city, industries that excite you, bad news story, cross-functional team story, how I like to learn/be coached, 3 strengths that your colleagues would say you possess

Any curveballs?

Prompt presented on screen and simultaneously read by the interviewer - that can get confusing! Also, preference for Bain vs. other firms

Office-specific nuances?

Cases were the same across offices. However, behavioural questions were different for different offices



PRO TIP

- Be hypothesis-driven, and answer-first!
- Bain cases are exhibit heavy, get comfortable interpreting them and drawing relationships between different parts of the case

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences - LEK

Format

R1 – 2 cases, one strategy, one maths

R2 – 3 parts: case with MD, work planning exercise* and summary slide presentation

*given in advance of interview

Type of cases

Retail cases, combination of growth strategy and market entry

Behavioral questions

New initiative, leadership example, almost failure

Any curveballs?

Did not expect to be grilled in the slide presentation round. Also, MD in the final case looked distracted (common pattern across many interviewees)

Office-specific nuances?

None – format and cases almost uniform across offices



PRO TIP

- LEK's interview process is a test of resilience – stay calm and patient, staying in your seat for 4 hours takes a lot out of you
- LEK throws 4 exhibits at you at the same time – go in with a hypothesis, don't attack everything

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences – PwC/ Strategy&

Format

Power round with 3 back-to-back 45-min interviews. All 3 interviews had some behaviorals and then 30-min cases.

Type of cases

Personal insurance (profitability), health insurance (market entry), and IT (cost reduction)

Behavioral questions

tell me about yourself, why consulting, why Strategy&, a couple of stories on strength, feedback, leadership

Any curveballs?

Did not expect an unstructured case! One of the interviews had no exhibits, interviewer was developing case on the go, there was no data when asked for!

Office-specific nuances?

None – format and cases almost uniform across offices



PRO TIP

- Customize your presentation to the case
- Be sure that you understood the prompt correctly before proceeding. There might be a lot of industry-specific info in the prompt, clarify about these by asking lots of questions!

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences – Kearney

Format

- R1 – 2 interviews, one behavioural, one case (45 min each)
- R2 – 3 interviews: two cases and one behavioural (45 min each)

Type of cases

Every type of case is possible but focus mostly on cost and operations related cases

Behavioral questions

New initiative, leadership example, almost failure

Any curveballs?

Straightforward interviews

Office-specific nuances?

None – format and cases almost uniform across offices



PRO TIP

- Kearney interviewers write their own cases based their project experience
- Most Kearney cases don't have exhibits and are relatively heavy on quant

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences – Deloitte

Format

2 rounds, 1st round: 1x45 min case + 1x45 min behavioral,
Final Round: 1x45 min in-person case + brief "behavioral" which was really just like a debrief of the case / discussing further strategy

Type of cases

Interviewee-led with guidance; cases in agriculture, retail and supply chain industries

Behavioral questions

What do you think is your superpower? How do you approach a hard problem?

Any curveballs?

Exhibit heavy. Exhibits are meant to overwhelm with too much information, they were not confusing/tricky like Bain



PRO TIP

- Complex exhibits -- use quick judgement to eliminate as many irrelevant data points as possible and avoid unnecessary math
- The presentation was a little different - use it as a way to show your personality and ability to work with people. much less formulaic.

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences – Accenture

Format

- R1 – 2 parts: case & behavioral (Consultants, Managers)
- R2 – 2 parts: case & behavioral (Senior Managers, MDs)

Type of cases

Utilities, Pharma or anything else, "traditional" case topics

Behavioral questions

New initiative, leadership example, motivations, almost failure

Any curveballs?

Questions can sometimes get more at your personal motivations than professional accomplishments

Office-specific nuances?

None – national hiring model



- Accenture's interviews can be unpredictable, and it's important to roll with whatever direction things take – stay calm, focused and engaged
- Accenture wants to know who you are – be prepared to potentially go into what motivates and is important to you

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences - AlixPartners

Format

Telephone screening followed by 3-part interview: 2 case interviews and one behavioral interview

Type of cases

1 industrials and 1 retail case. Long prompt, very number-heavy case

Behavioral questions

Working with someone with a diff managerial style, misconceptions about me, biggest accomplishment

Any curveballs?

Behavioral questions were not ordinary, to put mildly. Also, did not expect so many follow-up questions

Office-specific nuances?

None – format and cases almost uniform across offices



PRO TIP

- Cases are number-heavy: stay calm, and take your time identifying which numbers to look at and with the calculations
- For behaviorals – it's okay to get thrown off, ask for 10 seconds and think about your existing stories that might make sense if repackaged a bit

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences – Roland Berger

Format

2 Rounds - (First Round is 45min Case & 15min Behavioral, Second is 45min case & 45min behavioral)

Type of cases

Interviewer-led. Industrials case in auto and energy

Behavioral questions

Very standard behavioral questions. Leadership, strengths, failures

Any curveballs?

Second round interview was unstructured. Just given a powerpoint with prompt and exhibits



PRO TIP

- Know the "3 E's" for Roland Berger, and know about the firm and its position in US (small, growing, new Detroit office, etc.)

Firm-Specific Interview Experiences - EYP

Format

1 Superday:
2 case rounds (Both 45 minutes each)
1 behavioural round (45 minutes)

Type of cases

M&A (Tourism) and M&A (Fashion Retail)

Behavioral questions

Teamwork, Conflict, Manage upwards, Resume-specific questions on past work exp, "Additional section" questions on extra-curriculars

Any curveballs?

One of the M&A cases focused just on "giving ideas": brainstorming (3-4 questions) + frameworks (asked 2 frameworks, one after exhibits)

Office-specific nuances?

Maybe read-up a little on practice that you are interviewing with: DT, SSG or Core/Generalist



PRO TIP

- Heavy M&A focus and don't forget to practice behaviours!
- Focus a lot on brainstorming and structuring your thoughts!

Managing Nerves

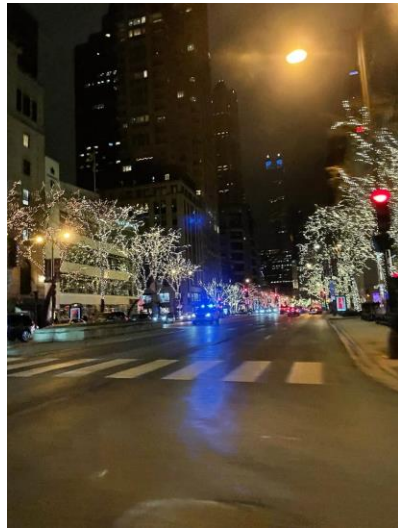
- Fixed vs Growth Mindset
- Amping yourself up / calming yourself down
- Self-talk & visualization
- Meditation / go for a walk
- Call a loved one / talk to someone who knows how great you are
- As much as possible, convince yourself / pretend like you already have an offer
- Superman poses

Power posing



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=S503PzZoQBg&ab_channel=HannahWadFans

Smarak's experience in December



TL, DR: Did everything possible to give myself rest before a long interview season, and get into game mode

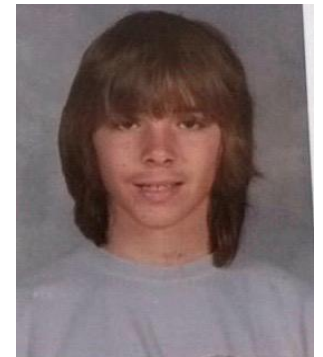
Ashley's revised experience in December

Looking back on last year, I wish I would have...

1. Had a mindset of abundance instead of scarcity and acted like I had nothing to lose
2. Kept my mind and body as healthy as possible by getting rest, going outside, meditating, watching/doing things that make me laugh
3. Calmed myself down before each interview instead of amped myself up
4. Leaned on friends and family more for support



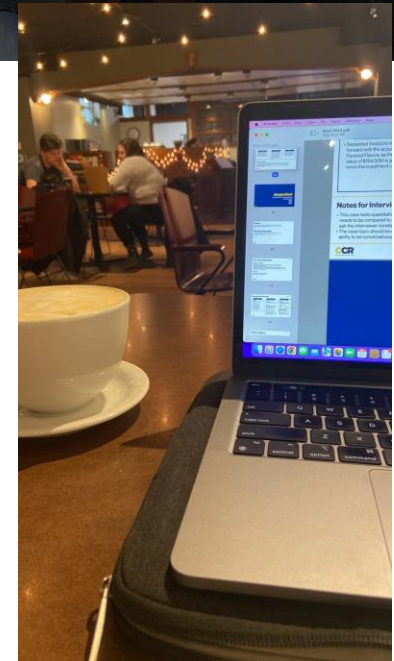
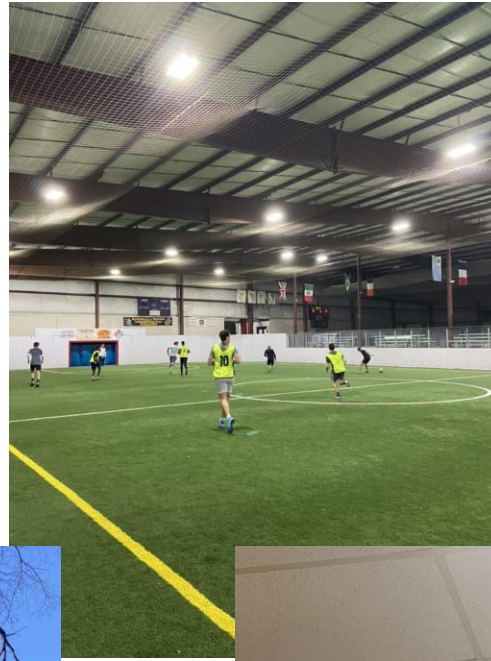
Life is
tough
but so
are
you.



Morgan's experience in December



Aman's experience in December



Final Preparation Reminders

- **Casing Rythm**
 - Have you recorded yourself doing a case yet?
 - Have you found your key weakness areas?
 - Have you explored cases from different industries, cased with different people?
- **Case Review**
 - Are you spending enough time to review the case (within 24 hrs.)?
 - If math was a struggle, re-do the math!!! (Don't cheat – do it for real)
- **Drills**
 - Are you speaking out your framework, brainstorm and interpretation of charts?
- **Behavioral**
 - Do you have your 5-6 main stories buttoned up?
 - Are you comfortable telling your odyssey in a manner that inspires and is memorable?
- **Find your community**
 - Do you know who you will do prep with over winter break?
 - Be kind to each other but give each other honest and constructive feedback!

Planning ahead for Winter Break – CCR Casing Program

Group Formation & Schedule

- Groups of 3 will be randomly assigned and announced this week (Week of December 4th)
- Each partnership will last for 2 weeks starting the **Week of December 11th**.
- After the two-week period beginning on **December 11th**, we will reshuffle and announce new groups

Casing Process

- **Quid Pro Quo** basis - "I case you, you case me" approach
- **Weekly Sessions:** 4-hour commitment every week. Each person gives 2 cases and gets to solve 2 cases in a week

Opt-Out Option: Decide before **10th of December** if you wish to participate

No Show? Have a protocol. Inform your case partner immediately. Offer a make-up session.

Participants with 2 unexplained no-shows in any 2-week partnership will be considered opted out of the program

Notes:

- Participants with different skill levels, language barriers and time zones
- Share any critical preferences about time zones, day preferences with your partners
- Be constructive with your feedback but be kind to your classmates!
- If you have questions, reach out to Shweta Tiwari, Sneha Kannan and Siddhartha Srinadhuni

In FACT group, you will discuss your detailed plan for winter break

Group Breakouts & Takeaways

- Spend the next 10 minutes talking to peers on your tables
- Discuss your interview preparation strategy over the next month
- Do you have any final questions for us?



On behalf of the CCR Ed team, thank you & good luck!



Appendix

Before Your Interviews

Behavioral Stories

- **Check out** the themes in the behavioral template and look through the sample questions
- **Prepare stories** that can be used to answer one or more of these questions – remember to structure them using the CAR format

Practice your Behaviorals

- **Schedule a practice behavioral interview** with FACT group leader after Thanksgiving
- **Practice your responses** OUT LOUD by yourself or with classmates

Don't forget your Cases!

- **Continue to reflect on your mock case interviews**, keep your case tracker updated and start to hone in on your areas of weakness – this is where your focus should be now!



Get outside, see
family/friends, go
on a walk...stay
healthy!!

Our goal is to help you excel against the following hiring criteria

Could I put you on a project tomorrow?

Can you do the work?

Structured, Analytical,
and Creative Thinker /
Problem Solver

A Leader, Impactful,
History of
(Over)Achievement

Organized,
Strong Project Manager,
Team Player

Can I put you in front of clients?

Great Communicator - Written & Oral:
Clear and Concise with Tone
Appropriate to Situation

Strong Executive Presence,
Influential Beyond Span of Control

Seeks Challenges,
Handles Pressure

Would I enjoy working with you?

Positive, Can Do Attitude,
Coachable

Driven to Add Value

Interesting and Interested
(Airport Test)

These are the criteria used to evaluate your resume, fit interviews, casing and networking.

- Do not try to anticipate individual questions (there are too many)!
- Prepare several “core” stories that can be used to answer a variety of questions
 - **Recommendation: 5 core stories and 3 backup stories**
 - Highlight Core Consulting Skills
 - Leadership
 - Teamwork
 - Resolve conflict
 - Persuade someone
 - Etc.
- **Homework:** document the names of your core stories

Context

- **Keep it short:** Give the context needed for the interviewer to understand the actions you took
- Frame the problem: leave them asking, **“wow, how did you handle that?”**

Action

- Share what **you** did given the problem that shows the **core skill** the question asked
- **Add Structure:** “3 steps I took,” “2 factors I considered,” etc.
- *Be cautious of saying “we” here, and be sure to make the action is about what YOU did*

Result*

- Detail the impact of your actions
- Quantify where possible
- Include **learning** *only if it was profound or lifechanging* to show that you have a growth mindset + learned to adapt
- End on a positive note

Tips: spend most of your time on “Action” to show how your actions were critical to success; use first-person and action-based language

Evaluation Factors: Are you...

Hypothesis Driven: You can understand new situations and form a hypothesis to guide your analysis.

YOU, AN
INCREDIBLE
CONSULTANT

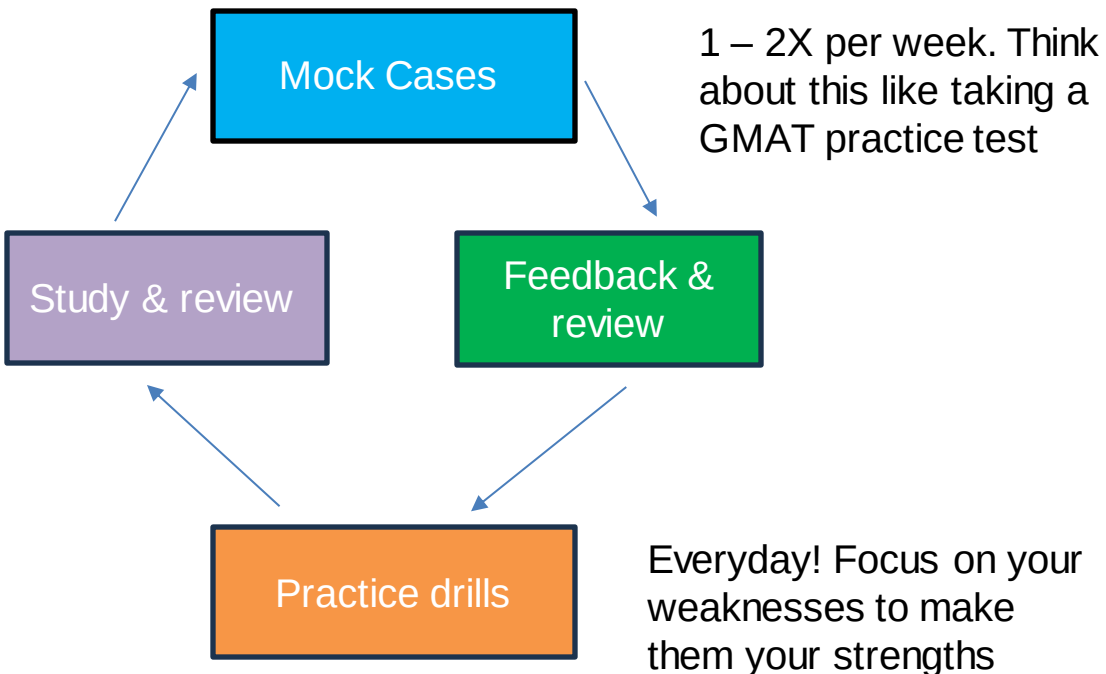
Structured: you can bring structure to complex problems; break them down to independent, manageable components

Analytical: There is analytical rigor to your conclusions and recommendations. Are you comfortable with numbers?



Engaged: Are you engaging and enjoyable to work with? You still need to be professional.

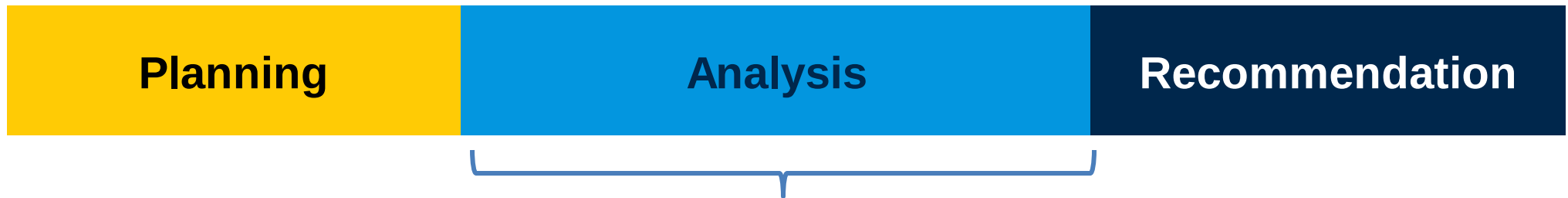
How to Practice



When doing mock cases:

- After each mock case, spend time to revisit it. Look for ways to improve
- Take notes about your findings – Case log
- Take the feedback seriously – it's for you to improve
- Do cases with different people. Everyone's style is different, and you will have a lot of constructive feedback.
- Once you feel more comfortable, do cases with people who make you nervous to fail in front of OR ask your friend to impersonate someone who is less friendly

Case Interview (~30 Minutes)



Brainstorming questions

- Be structured, even if the interviewer says to not be structured

Quant

- Eyes on the prize: How is the info you're given relevant to the goal?
- Organize the math on your paper and explain what you're doing
- Calculate and drive the case forward --> what's next?

Charts

- Take a moment to orient yourself, make sure you look at each axis and all footnotes – clarify anything that is unclear
- Dive into key findings but *always keep your goal in mind*
- Be curious and interested in second layer insights and move the case forward

Bringing it all together: Planning

Case Interview (~30 Minutes)

Planning

Analysis

Recommendation

Prompt

- Focus on what the interviewer is saying & write down important elements
- Think through any personal references, new articles, or work experience you have that might be relevant and interesting to the case

Clarifying Questions

- Take a breath, and think about what questions you would need to answer to better understand the situation or goal
- *Do not ask questions just to ask questions*

Framework

- Aim for ~2 mins, longer is OK for a great framework
- Make it as MECE as possible
- Try to think of one creative / innovative / personal idea for every framework
- Move the case forward by having an area you want to start looking into

Bringing it all together: Recommendation

Case Interview (~30 Minutes)

Planning

Analysis

Recommendation

Recommendation

Take a moment to gather your thoughts
Keep it concise!

Follow the 3-step process:

1. **Present recommendation:** Always take a stance
2. **Briefly Recap:** re-emphasize how you got to your recommendation
3. **Address any risks:** we're there assumptions you made in the calculations that influenced your decision?
4. **List next steps:** what is the most logical next thing you'd want to look into?

1. **Structured:** Have clear buckets and sub-buckets and be able to explain them succinctly
2. **Tailored:** Make it customized to the problem you're trying to solve
3. **"MECE" --> Mutually Exclusive Collectively Exhaustive**
 - Mutually Exclusive: No two buckets have the same sub-buckets
 - Collectively Exhaustive: Together, your framework covers all possible explanations
4. **Multi-layered**
 - Aim for 3's – 3 main buckets, 3 sub-buckets beneath each main bucket, *but this is NOT a rule*
5. **Creative:** Think outside the box, if time allows
6. **Hypothesis driven:** Have an idea of which bucket you think is the best solution to achieve the clients goal

When you do case math, you should be chasing the ***goal*** of the case.

1. Pause & make sense of the data – **don't just start calculating** something because you can
2. Talk through your plan **out loud**
3. Deal with the **pressure and complexity** (a lot of 0's, time, etc.)
4. Always put your answer in **context**, how does this tie to the goal of the case?

How to Approach Charts and Tables

■ Keep in mind your objective

- You probably received the chart because you asked for some information, so look at it as a way to answer the question you had (aka test your hypothesis)
- Be mindful of how the interviewer has framed the material - they will usually “introduce” the chart

■ Clear the chart

- Take a deep breath & orient yourself
- Pay attention to: axes, title, legend, footnotes (carefully) - talk through what you're seeing and if you're unsure what a piece of info means, clarify

■ Engage in a dialogue to share your observations/insights

- Key insights/findings
- Go beyond the obvious (second-level insights, calculation, connections, inter-dependencies)
- Relate everything back to the original question and your original hypothesis
- Propose next steps
- Remember, they care more about how you communicate the findings than the findings themselves

- Brainstorming involves connecting information from the case with core classes, business concepts, and real-world knowledge
- Opportunity to show creativity + structure + problem solving skills

When will I get brainstorm questions?

- Brainstorming can occur before or after quantitative analysis / chart clearing

How do I recognize brainstorming questions?

- Any question you're asked outside of the prompt that asks for deeper insights and does not involve quantitative analysis
- Questions that require a paragraph, not a sentence, to answer
- Many brainstorming questions ask you to consider multiple factors

- **Do:**

- **Ask for a moment** (~30 secs) to structure thoughts on scratch paper
 - If they say, "no," then continue with the advice below (this can happen!)
- Repeat your ideas back in a structured way (**like a mini-framework!**)

Pros vs. cons

Short term vs.
long term

Fixed vs.
variable costs

of categories

- **Do Not:**

- **Jump into an answer without structuring it first**
- **Give a stream of consciousness**

- ...What if the interviewer asks, “**Anything else?**”

- Either you missed something or it's a pressure test
- Dive into anything else you have, or suggest a direction to go next (*though recognize when you've exhausted all ideas*)
- McKinsey **WILL** ask

- The recommendation wraps up the case by **answering the main question** from the prompt
- Put a stake in the ground: it should be clear, it should be highly specific to case, it should reference your case analysis
- Speak as if you're talking to client
- Expect to take 30-45 seconds to prep (if available) and ~1 minute to deliver the rec.
- **Tip:** Note **quant results, risks, and next steps** as you go through the case
- **Note:** Interviewer-led cases may skip recs
 - Or, they may have a question that is not verbatim, "what is the recommendation" but will insinuate to wrap-up the case

Casing Feedback: Don't forget about delivery & presentation



Casing is just as much about how you present yourself as it is your ability to solve the case.

- 1. Be excited to solve the case:** Consulting work will be similar to casing. You should be having fun with it! Practice showing off your excitement in your mock interviews – if you're not practicing it, you won't do it on interview day.
- 2. Pay attention to tone inflection:** This will keep your interviewer engaged and excited to work with you by keeping your energy high
- 3. Speak with confidence:** Consultants often have to solve ambiguous problems in industries they've never worked in before. Your goal in the case interview will be to show that you can be confident in many different client situations.
- 4. Be creative:** Avoid ubiquitous scripted language such as "let me take a moment to structure my thoughts" or re-reading the prompt word-for-word. Be more creative here and put this language in your own voice!

What makes a great behavioral answer

- **Structured:** Follow the CAR format so you give the interviewer just enough **context** to follow along, get to the **action** of the story, and follow up with the **results** and, if applicable, your **learning**.
- **Personal:** Only you have lived your experiences. This is your chance to own them and have your interviewer get to know you better. Avoid making it look like you're infallible
- **Interesting:** Make sure your story has some tension (but please remember it should still be professional) - but make it interesting to listen to and follow along. This includes being sure you're not using tons of industry jargon your interviewer won't know.
- **What not to do:** Badmouth others, over OR undershare, spend 90 seconds on context. Be human!

*CDO's
3-step
guide*

Identify the theme of the question

What key attribute/skill is the interviewer trying to assess? Conflict resolution? Leadership? Teamwork?

Think strategically

How do you want to phrase your answer?
What emotions do you want to present? What skills do you want to highlight?

Manage the message!

What key takeaways do you want the interviewer to have? (for eg – how do you want them to describe you as a leader?)

The fit interview also allows the interviewer to learn about your specific interests in their firm and in consulting in general

Why Consulting? Why us?



It's important to firms that they recruit professionals who have been thoughtful in their decisions



The amount of research/face time you have put in with the firm will come through in these questions



You should have **specific reasons** as to why you want to pursue Consulting over another field, and why you are interested in the firms you are interviewing for

TIPS for "why this firm?"

Utilize prior research on the firm to customize this response to whoever you are interviewing with.

- **Connect your specific career interests** with certain practices within the firm/recent projects the firm has engaged in. ***This is the most important of the four bullets here!!!**
- Reference **specific conversations/interactions** you have had with individuals from the firm throughout recruiting events on campus
- **Make it personal** – factor in life considerations, such as office location, travel schedule, staffing model, family/partner perks, etc. into your consideration for their firm
- Consider **firm culture, professional development approach (specialization vs. Generalist), staffing model (office-based vs. National)** when thinking about this answer

McKinsey Behavioral Interview: PEI

If you're interviewing with McKinsey, they will give you the PEI questions in advance. All questions they will ask (word-for-word) are listed [HERE](#).

How are PEI's different?

- **Length:** You'll be expected to have one story per question that will take ~10 minutes to tell
- **Weight:** PEI's are weighed very heavily at McKinsey – so spend time preparing for them!
- **Structure:** You should plan to give a brief overview of the story and check with the interviewer that the story is a good fit. Have a back up planned if they say no. McKinsey also follows the STAR format: **S**ituation, **T**ask, **A**ction, **R**esult.
- **Follow up Questions:** You may be asked to expand on parts of your story or dive deeper in a direction you weren't expecting – know every aspect of your story and be able to speak to it (and always share honest stories – they'll know if you're making things up as you go)
- **Impact:** Choose stories where you had a tangible impact (it doesn't have to be a big impact) and can show personal growth

If you want more information or help preparing, book a PEI mock interview through Ross Recruit or email an MBA2 who interned at McKinsey!